

QLD 1KM PROJECT - Gemini Mountains - The Pregnant Lady

Initially searching about Google Earth for work, the keen wandering highline goggles of Patrick ventured north west, well into outback Queensland. Stumbling upon a kilometer gap in a very flat landscape that where geology protrudes the surface, it astounds, volcanic plugs form incredible peaks amongst a seemingly barren place.

It became obvious quickly that a project in such a unique environment had to happen. Following conversations with Gabe and Arthur, rallied enough stoke to conjure up a plan before Patrick was to leave Australia on holiday.



Enough to tease any avid highliner, a crew amassed that were keen to commit to the journey north. Some participants driving all the way from Victoria!

Considering plenty of unknowns, all were motivated with gut feelings that this would be more than just a highline mission.

Arthur recollected following a local to that area (Wangan & Jagalingou) so prior to embarking, contacted Gurridyula. A man of many words and much wisdom, who was excited to hear of our intentions, ensuring we were welcome to the Gemini Mountains, otherwise known as The Pregnant Lady, a women's site. Tying in what we all need on such endeavors, "the pregnant lady needs water". "Life needs water", and Gurridyula's story expresses much of the disdain to mining destroying an ancient spring on his land. A wildlife hub and significant revisited area by aboriginals in times of drought. His people are the only indigenous people to walk back onto and occupy their ancestral lands (utilizing Qld's human rights act 2019 - to perform ceremonies on mining leases) he has had a "ceremonial" fire burning for nearly 1500 days now.

He was stoked to hear we wanted to raise solidarity to Doongmabulla Springs with a banner.

His acceptance to us was just the beginning. Its not what you know, its who you know. His cousin worked for national parks, his friend Pete was the head ranger. Things were kept quiet as did our aim to get permission "only through Gurridyula". He gained us access that would otherwise have left us having to walk an extra 10km from allocated camp spot. We were able to pick and choose our home for the week.

A spiritual welcoming with a smoking ceremony, to let the pregnant lady know we were here, followed by fireside stories settled us into the place after the 18hr drive up. His grandfather was born very close to the peaks at Logan river, “before the wagon wheels even rocked up”. Priceless insights into what would be our usual endeavor, became inevitable to align with his passion for connection to country, hence his “intellectual property” and loop hole in modern society.

With plenty organized prior to the trip (webbing taped, bags stuffed full etc) we spent first night finalizing gear, sorting anchor material, followed by a much needed sleep. First sunrise, caffeine and a morning meeting, allocated teams to the now appropriated true status of “The Head” of the pregnant lady for Mount Castor, and “The Belly” (Mount Pollux).



It begins.

Building anchors was harder than first assumed. Gear into finger pockets and cracks, blowing out cams from chalky holes, to be replaced with a bigger sizes that would work. Many legs holding down A frames, many shrubs and many chefs to conjure up sound anchors on either side.

Tagging with drones went well at first, but smooth operation with Art and Gabe on the sticks turned sour when fishing line got caught up in the valley below. The first day of attempts turned into finding and freeing up tagline. Which when retagged, damage to the line meant when successfully retrieving on the drill from the belly side, snapped. We had to rethink everything.

That second night, Mattias proposed tagging from the middle. Discussions ultimately led to this as a team went to the middle of the peaks the next morning. Fishing line tagged to the head from the middle successfully, and we pulled through tagline. Next, an ambitious Art took to naturally tagging the rest with Gabe. Ascending the belly directly to gain its ridge to the anchor. That beautiful moment when Gerrard let go in the middle, the ping! What a beautiful sound. The gap was tagged.

Curtain rod worked perfectly on the rig, with Chopra (Florescia) able to pull in most of the line by herself as others bagged tag. The pregnant lady however threw us another curve ball, gusting the

tagline enough to wrap around the line. Gabe to the rescue, sent the line first go, whilst also leaning down to untangle the sections when he got to them. Round of applause to a ridiculous level of highline shenanigans. He walked back also. The pregnant lady accepted us there and we were all descended on the days success. Having spent at least 48 hours troubleshooting the tagging alone it was good to return to camp with the line up.



Following days allowed for multiple sends from the likes of Arthur, Lef and Gabe again. Crossing the line was Patrick, Gerard, Chopra, Mattias. Energy was on a high. The team was accruing many personal bests. Vibes high at our temporary home on the corner, watching the moon setting as the sun rose and vice versa, a magic alignment of people and nature's beauty.

With the arrival of Alex and Acacia, excited to get fresh feet on the line the next day, all fell into a deep slumber.....

Not your average alarm clock!

“WHOPP!! WHOPP!! WHOPP!! WHOPP!! WHOPP!!”

The line was singing.

Patrick and Gabe first off to assess, eventually going to the head side to try and release some tension. A team quickly made it to belly as well, Gerard first, reading over UHF “10.5kN”. Head side ended up jamming under crazy tension where rope was eventually cut to release, somehow A frames still stable and sound. Belly managed to release onto a 200m static and achieve a low force on the line. Time to start thinking about de-rig.

If any lesson was to be learned, it would be to place the curtain rod in a non interfering position. Things worsened when wind picked up the tag and wrapped it around the back up. Allowing for other parts to flutter and fly around and get intertwined and wrapped around each other also. No solution and a lot of webbing to retrieve on a useless system, we decided that with a clearing in the valley, we would have to release from both sides to let down all webbing to the ground in the middle.

All good in theory and from belly side, though the tangle issues meant when head side released, webbing and tagline found itself not sliding to the middle, but immersed into a forest below.

Some ballsy tree climbing and much persistent untangling, finally retrieved all webbing, astoundingly unharmed. We would return the next day to retrieve curtain rod and tagline.

The pregnant lady definitely called things short, carried away we missed the opportunity to have the banner rigged with the line. John had carried it to the top of the belly and with the line down, we got some shots anyway, and as everyone had departed, leaving no trace, two decided to venture further north to check in with Gurridyula one last time.

Bill and Arthur saw it for themselves, a confronting scenario in such a beautiful place. Waddananggu is rich in history but has sadly been terraformed by Adani mine. His fight to save Doongmabulla springs (10km from Waddananggu / Mine Site) is real. Representing more than acknowledgment and potentially setting a precedent for a reclaiming revolution. More to point a finger at the ruthless nature of industry, despite our need for resources. Wuni-gu Wuni-gu as he puts it, meaning give to give to, sums up a humble attitude of only take what you can replace. Whereas despite job creation, the bigger investment for future generations is water. The springs have flowed unhindered for at least half a billion years, have been researched thoroughly, with peer reviewed projects highlighting the obvious damage that needs to stop. Adani has till the end of this year to prove otherwise. Connecting our endeavor not just to a gap between mountains, but to the deep history and current issue for the original custodians has removed much of the access stigma to sacred places. Having his narrative and wisdom was what made this much more than just a highline mission.